

OakBerry's Global Expansion into Ireland: A Case Study- CA3



Strategic Marketing (B8MN101_2425_TMD1)

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OakBerry's Global Expansion into Ireland

Abstract

Our case study examines the expansion of Oakberry into the Irish market and analyses the challenges faced by the business and how it overcame them to become successful. Some of the challenges include the acai product being relatively unknown at the time of expansion, reducing the potential customers of the business. Another issue they faced was the complex supply chain needed to import acai into Ireland, as the berry is unable to grow in the Irish climate.

To succeed and position themselves in the Irish market, they used several methods. They promoted sustainability in their marketing, aiming to appeal to the younger, environmentally conscious consumers. They also capitalised on the growing desire for healthy food by running a social media campaign, partnering with influencers, local brands and informing consumers of the benefits of acai. Our five forces analysis showed that they faced a high amount of competition upon entry, causing issues for Oakberry as they set up their business.

To further our research, we interviewed Nick Twomey, a key member of the Irish franchise of Oakberry. We gathered several insights that we used to inform our conclusion and recommendations. These include sustainable recommendations, broadening their target market and investing in vending machines.

1. Introduction

OakBerry, a Brazilian brand known for its acai-based products, started in Brazil back in 2016, and it's quickly grown into a brand that people recognize for its acai bowls and smoothies. Founded in Brazil in 2016, OakBerry offers a variety of acai bowls, smoothies, and over 15 topping options, ranging from banana and granola to organic honey and goji, primarily made from acai berries sourced directly from the Amazon rainforest. The brand has built its reputation on offering fresh, healthy options for people who want something quick but nutritious, a healthier alternative to fast food. (OakBerry, 2022)

Over the years, OakBerry has expanded rapidly, globally, in present in 2025 has over 400 stores in Brazil and Europe. (OakBerry, 2022) The brand chose to expand into Ireland, a market with a growing interest in healthy eating, particularly acai bowls and plant-based diets. The Irish market, with its trend towards wellness and fitness, presented a unique opportunity for OakBerry to introduce its offerings to a new demographic. (Pollock, 2024)

This case study will look at OakBerry's entry into the Irish Market- existing gaps from the literature review will have a look at the specific challenges and opportunities of adapting a global fast-food business model into the Irish market as well as the impact of the local laws and specific consumers preferences; what was that success factor/model that they used in a new country; how it marketed its products, the marketing strategy used, the challenges it faced, and the opportunities that helped it establish itself in a country where healthy food choices are becoming more popular.

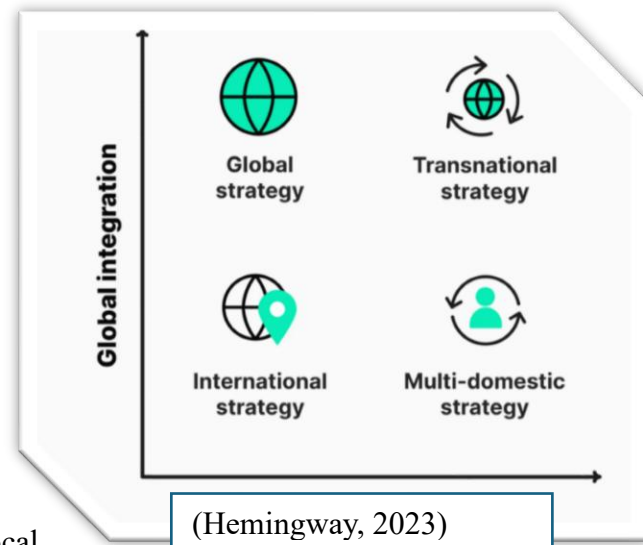
2. Literature Review on Global Expansion

2.1 Global Expansion in Marketing

According to Hemingway (2023), global expansion (international expansion) happens when a company extends its operations into new regions/markets beyond its home country. Smartling (2024) and Hemingway (2023) agreed that this kind of growth brings several benefits, including more customers, stronger brand recognition, and higher revenue. Nevertheless, there are also difficulties to consider, such as language barriers, cultural differences, legal restrictions, and financial risks like inconsistent currency values. Some markets may already have strong local competition or be less open to foreign brands, which can make it harder to succeed. As per the information from Darrell (2022), each business's global expansion strategy will look different/unique to accommodate their approach/strategy, as there's no one ideal solution/plan for all businesses.

According to research by Hemingway (2023) and Darrell (2022), businesses often follow four key Global expansion strategies:

- **International:** This is when a business enters a new market without making many changes to its products or pricing (the most common)
- **Multi-domestic strategy** - Here, companies adapt their products and marketing to match local customs and consumer needs.
- **Global Strategy** - This strategy aims to create cost-efficient operations that can be used across multiple markets, minimizing the need for local adjustments.
- **Transnational Strategy** - A mix of both, where businesses try to adjust their products for each market while also maintaining efficiency and cost control.



Research from Gupta et al. (2024) highlighted that a deep understanding of the target market is essential and crucial for successful global expansion. This means knowing or learning (studying) the local economy, consumer behaviour, legal regulations, and cultural differences.

2.2 Challenges of Global Expansion

According to Cote (2020), the possibilities of global expansion can be appealing, but businesses often face significant difficulties. The most common ones are:

- **Cultural Barriers:** To succeed in a new market, businesses need to adapt their products and marketing strategies to local tastes. A product that has success in one country might not be as successful in another due to cultural barriers in taste.
- **Legal Difficulties:** Each country has different regulations concerning product standards, packaging, labour laws, and food safety standards. These can delay business entry into the market and increase costs.
- **Market Competition:** Entering a new market means facing local strong competitors which already have loyal customers and market knowledge. (Cote, 2020)

2.3 Opportunities in Global Expansion

Canpolat (2024) agreed with Gupta et al. (2024) that global expansion can offer businesses access to several key opportunities, for example:

- ⊆ **Market Growth:** Expanding into new regions/countries allows businesses to have access to new customer segments and increase sales.
- ⊆ **Diversification:** By operating in multiple markets, companies can reduce their dependence on one market, thus mitigating risks related to economic downturns in specific regions.
- ⊆ **Brand Recognition:** International expansion allows a brand to enhance its visibility and reputation globally, attracting international and local customers.



(Gupta et al.2024)

To have a better understanding of what Global expansion, challenges and opportunities arise in a business, will have a closer look at Oakberry, a company specializing in açai-based products; expanding internationally was a natural move when the sales increased and gained a reputation in its market, Brazil. When the brand first launched, in 2016 in Brazil it followed a franchise model, meaning independent store owners sold OakBerry's products, which were supplied by a third-party manufacturer (Oakberry, 2022). However, between 2017 and 2021, Oakberry experienced rapid growth both in Brazil and overseas. To keep up with demand and improve efficiency, the company decided to change its business model. By late 2022, it had taken full control of its açai production, allowing for better quality management and a more streamlined supply chain (Oakberry, 2022).

3. OakBerry's Global Expansion Strategy

3.1 Entry Strategy into Ireland

OakBerry's decision to enter the Ireland market was determined by the country's growing interest in healthy eating and wellness. The strategy adopted when the business opened its first store in 2023 was a franchise network model for its entry into the Irish market. The franchise model allowed them to partner with local entrepreneurs who understood the regional market dynamics and consumer preferences as well as being the only brand that has complete ownership of its supply chain. (Walsh, 2024)



(Oakberry, 2022)

The brand established its first location in Dublin, strategically selecting areas near fitness centres and universities where the demand for healthy snacks is high. They also focused on opening stores in high-traffic areas, such as shopping malls (Blanchardstown, Ilac Centre), and city centre locations (The Anne Street) to maximise visibility. (Walsh, 2024)

3.2 Challenges Faced by OakBerry in Ireland

Cultural Adaptation: While acai bowls are popular in Brazil and other parts of the world, they were relatively new to Irish consumers at the time of OakBerry's entry. One major challenge was educating/informing consumers about acai as a superfood and its health benefits. OakBerry had to adjust its product and add local fruits instead of exotic ones and downsize the size of the package, investing in marketing to familiarise Irish customers with the product. (Walsh, 2024)

Local Competition: OakBerry faced competition from local health-focused cafes/shops, smoothie companies and other food chains that already offered healthy alternatives. (RocketReach,2023) Competing with these established brands (local businesses) required OakBerry to differentiate its products and communicate its unique selling proposition (USP), which is unique taste/combinations, nutritious fast-food and organic ingredients. (Oakberry, 2022)

Supply Chain Issues: The company had to ensure a steady supply of high-quality acai berries to meet demand in Ireland. This posed logistical challenges, as sourcing fresh ingredients from Brazil involved complex supply chain management, especially when dealing with perishable goods, they had to freeze the acai berries (paste/cream) to arrive fresh in Ireland.

3.3 Opportunities Explored by OakBerry

Health-Conscious Market: Ireland's growing health-conscious people provide OakBerry with a significant opportunity. The demand for organic, vegan, and gluten-free products was on the rise, which aligned with OakBerry's product offerings. (CBM, 2024)

Social Media Marketing: OakBerry took full advantage of digital marketing to spread brand awareness and create buzz around it. The brand used Instagram/social media platforms and hashtags popular among Gen Z and millennials but not limited to these demographics, showcasing appealing acai bowls and promoting health benefits. (CBM, 2024)

Collaborations and Partnerships: Collaborating with local influencers, local brands like PerfectTed, Dairy Glen and TikTok posts helped OakBerry build a connection with the Irish consumer and increase visibility among target demographics. By offering free samples to taste and sponsorships with local communities, OakBerry was able to reach a broader audience. (Walsh, 2024)

Sustainability and Ethical Considerations: OakBerry's sustainability strategy is based on 5 pillars that best suit the company:

- a.) **Sustainability Supply Chain**- The company actively supports Riverside communities through constant encouragement of this and goes beyond standard certifications.
- b.) **Healthy Food** – its product is organic certified, gluten-free and well-balanced nutritional plant, no artificial colouring or syrup.
- c.) **Minimal Climate Impact & Resource Use** – The Acai products are processed in its factories in Para and Midwest collaborating with their partners, and these factories have incorporated solar energy and water reuse infrastructure.
- d.) **Waste and Circular Economy**: Oakberry is committed to prioritising recycling in their packaging, aiming to reduce waste and to better inform their customers of sustainability in their waste.
- e.) **Diversity and Inclusion**: Oakberry has the goal of maintaining a diverse and safe workforce and is committed to promoting equality in the workplace. (OakBerry, 2022)

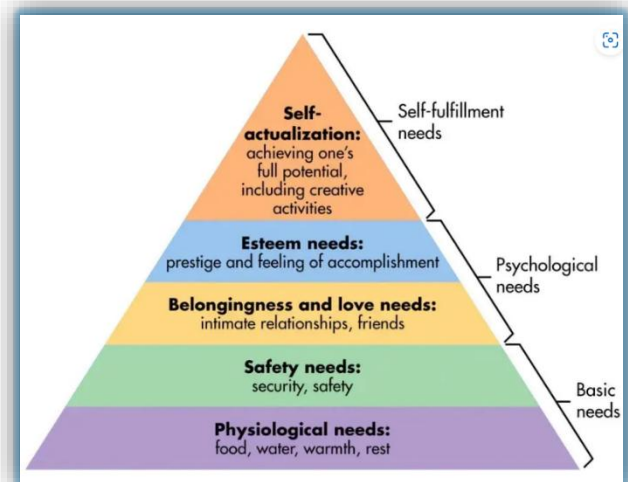


(Img. Oakberry, 2022)

OAKBERRY ESG Pillars	SASB Material Topic	Related ODSs
Sustainable Supply Chain	Yes	2 (Fair work & decent conditions), 15 (Responsible consumption and production)
Healthy Food	Yes	3 (Good health & well-being)
Minimal Climate Impact and natural resource use	Yes	6 (Clean water & sanitation), 7 (Affordable and clean energy), 13 (Climate action)
Waste and circular economy	Yes	12 (Responsible consumption and production)
Diversity and Inclusion	Cross-cutting theme across sectors	5 (Gender equality)

The marketing strategies used by Oakberry for the Irish market were the slight **adaptation of their product** to match the Irish tastes, for example, the choices with local fruits such as berries or apples, and they also introduced smaller portions and lower-priced options with easy-to-carry packaging. **Social media platforms** played a crucial role in promoting and engaging with their target audience, while most of their consumers shared/posted their products, increasing the visibility of the brand. Oakberry positioned itself **as a premium yet accessible brand** offering healthier, tasty and nutritious plant-based options which resonated with the growing trend of health-conscious consumers in the Irish market.

According to Needle (2021), a company appeals to consumers' behaviour, **esteem needs** by offering a product that allows them to feel good about making healthy food choices. Acai bowls, seen as both trendy and nutritious, also cater to **self-actualization needs** and a sense of accomplishment, helping customers maintain a healthy lifestyle and boost their well-being.



Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs (Needle, 2021)

4. Industry Overview and the Competitive Market

Applying **Porter's Five Forces** to OakBerry's entry into Ireland shows the competitive market:

- ⊆ **Threat of New Entrants:** The health food industry in Ireland is growing, with low barriers to entry. However, OakBerry's established brand and unique offering made it a strong competitor. (Team, 2024)
- ⊆ **Bargaining Power of Suppliers:** OakBerry relied heavily on suppliers for acai berries (shipped from Brazil). The bargaining power of suppliers was high due to the limited availability of quality acai. (Team, 2024)
- ⊆ **Threat of Substitutes:** The threat of substitutes was significant, as many local competitors are offering similar products like smoothies and salads. (Team, 2024)

- ⊂ **Buyer Power:** Irish consumers have high bargaining power due to the variety of healthy food options available. (Team, 2024)
- ⊂ **Industry Rivalry:** Competition was intense, with several established local health food chains. (Team, 2024)

By building awareness through digital marketing, using its strong brand, and making changes to the products it sells, OakBerry was able to grow successfully in Ireland. OakBerry seized possibilities in the expanding health food industry despite obstacles, including cultural adaption and competitiveness.



5. Primary Research

To better understand how OakBerry operates and positions itself in Ireland, we reached out to a team member for an email interview. We reached out to Nick, who had once participated as a guest speaker in our Marketing lecture at Dublin Business School.

The purpose of this correspondence was to gather qualitative data directly from someone with operational knowledge of OakBerry's business model, brand strategy, and sustainability practices in Ireland. A set of eight well-structured questions was emailed, each targeting a key dimension of our research focus: brand localisation, sustainability, consumer trends, market differentiation, pre-entry research, challenges, and future projections.

Below is a summary of the information received from Nick:

Global Brand Strategy Adaptation

Nick said that OakBerry's focus on health matches well with how more young people in Ireland are becoming interested in living a healthy lifestyle.

Sustainability Implementation in Ireland

Sustainability plays a crucial role in OakBerry's operations. Nick explained that their commitment to sustainability extends to sourcing organic ingredients, supporting Amazonian

communities through responsible açai harvesting, and using sustainable packaging wherever possible.

Consumer Response to Sustainability

According to Nick, Irish consumers have responded positively to OakBerry's sustainability message. You can see this in how often customers post about Oakberry on social media, especially pointing out its environmentally friendly values.

Market Differentiation

Oakberry distinguishes itself in the Irish health food market by offering authentic, natural açai bowls. A significant competitive advantage lies in their vertically integrated supply chain — from harvesting the berries to delivering the final product — with no intermediaries involved.

Pre-Market Entry Research

Before entering the Irish market, Oakberry conducted trend analysis through articles and social media and also organised a focus group to better understand local consumer preferences.

Consumer Behavior Trends

Since launching in Ireland, Oakberry has observed a growing demand for healthy eating options, with more consumers seeking nutritious alternatives.

Challenges and Opportunities

A problem they encountered during expansion was acquiring suitable retail premises. However, Nick expressed that their strong support system — comprising dedicated staff, loyal customers, and a reliable supply chain — has contributed to their successful growth.

Future Outlook

Looking ahead, Oakberry aims to continue offering authentic açai products while diversifying its menu. The brand plans to expand further by opening 15–20 new stores, positioning itself as the leading açai brand in Ireland.

This research gave us useful information about how Oakberry operates within the Irish market and its plans to grow its business, acting as a key part of our case study.



6. Conclusion and Recommendations

Regardless of the initial obstacles the Brazilian Açaí brand Oakberry had when it comes to Cultural adaptation, local competitors and supplier challenges in Ireland, the company managed to introduce their products to the Irish market, taking full advantage of the growing healthy trends in the European country, the brand was able to follow its identity and keep consistency thank to the franchise model they have which allows the company to have a smoother entrance in the new market since the franchisor offers all support needed such as equipment, training and marketing tools (Simpson, 2022).

The acceptance and demand for the product have also been rising due to the large Brazilian community in Ireland (Malone, 2024), which helped the brand gain visibility through word-of-mouth recommendations, making the Brazilian Açaí even more popular and known among younger generations. (Hayes et al., 2024).

The brand encourages clients to post on social media, which has brought the company a higher demand due to recent trends in fitness lifestyles, especially on Instagram. (Irish Examiner, 2025) This report also highlighted Porter's Five Forces analysis on the brand regarding the competitive landscape in which they operates and its possibilities in the Irish market. It indicated that pricing strategies, supplier relationships and differentiation were fundamental for positioning the brand in the market. (Gratton & Scott, 2024)

This report also highlighted the importance of analysing OakBerry's experience with global expansion and franchising. It also dived deep into market growth, diversification and opportunities that it capitalised on to find its success in Ireland. This can be used to compare to similar businesses attempting to sell unfamiliar products to markets in different countries and how best to approach that.



Recommendations:

Innovative recommendation: The brand can introduce boost immunity shots, especially during cold weather, and have supermarkets and pharmacies such as Boots resell them. This way, their products and income would not be limited to the Oakberry shops while growing brand awareness.

Using Broad Generational Spectrum Approach: Having only Generation Z as a target can be considered a great investment as this generation tends to spend a large amount of time on social media, which helps brands with their online advertisements, but they also have a short attention span and are attracted to brands based on their reputation and values (Warc, 2020), on the other hand, OakBerry's kind of product can be sold to anyone, if well marketed, whether they are Gen Z, Millennials, Gen X, Baby Boomers or Gen Alpha, as long as the brand keeps up with healthy eating trends, all the generations listed can be included in their target audience. (Wunsch, 2024)

Layout Improvement: Improving shop layouts for a more inviting, cosy and tropical look instead of only clinical and technological can make it more welcoming and impact consumers' perceptions and decisions more positively. (Katz, 2024)

Sustainable recommendation: With the growing concerns on sustainable practices of companies, for Gen Z, a brand that is sustainable is always ahead of the brands that aren't. (Kadymov, 2023) for this reason, Oakberry can demonstrate how environmentally friendly their products are by utilising reusable cups, spoons or straws and creating eco-friendly merchandise, such as notebooks and calendars. When it comes to sustainability, the brand can also launch campaigns related to sustainable practices, such as "Oakberry – the best you can do for the planet", where they educate customers and staff on the importance of recycling, for example. Another recommendation could be a campaign related to food wastage, where they offer extra portions of fruits or açai with a 50% discount before they have to waste it. This way, the company would reduce food wastage, still make a profit, be eco-friendly and gain credibility from their customers.

New models for the future: Offering student discounts and loyalty cards to accumulate points for free açai after purchasing a certain number of products would encourage students to return and build customer loyalty. This strategy would also help gather customer data to understand the target market and their expectations, forecast future trends, and track client habits, keeping the company up-to-date.

AI implementation & Avatar on the app: With customer personalisation, by implementing AI, Oakberry would be able to create a better business-to-client connection, which can build trust. (Tenzer, 2024) Creating avatars would allow all customers to edit their avatars based on their preferences to reflect their characteristics and interact with them, it would make customers feel connected and engage more with the brand; it would position the brand as an exceptional food experience to have rather than just an Açai shop. (Lu, 2024)

Send customers notifications: The company can use their app to share healthy facts, trends, collaborations, and the benefits of Açai. Having these connected to the website would bring more visits and keep customers engaged.

Vending machines: Oakberry can implement vending machines in gyms, airports, and parks offering açai juice.



7. Individual Components

Cristina's Question: How can OakBerry raise its market share and brand awareness even further in the Irish market?

Answer: Oakberry can think and develop a larger range/adding more items/options to its original product line to accommodate consumers with a bigger range of dietary needs and restrictions. Adding more options to these consumers in need of dietary products, gluten-free allergies will appeal to a niche which currently doesn't have access and will increase popularity in the Irish market as well as Globally. For example, adding new superfood bowls, shakes, or snacks that suit a range of tastes and are visually appealing at least once a month, a new product could be a strategy to do this. They might also think of appealing to their consumers to play with the existing ingredients and create new recipes and post them online or have them in their range of products, which will increase the engagement and popularity among existing clients and attract new ones. Oakberry can form partnerships with local farmers and suppliers to emphasise its dedication to supporting organic and sustainable food production. In addition to boosting the local economy, their prices will be kept low, and the distribution channels will be easier to manage. That's how Oakberry can guarantee the freshness and quality of its goods by obtaining ingredients locally. Engaging more in the community and participating/sponsoring will gain a sense of pertinence to the local consumers and gain popularity among every target group.

Hellen's Question: What strategies can the brand implement to succeed in Ireland during colder times?

Answer: During winter and cold periods people tend to look for comfort food such as soups, vegetables and warmer dishes rather than ice cream or smoothies, with that, companies such as Oakberry can struggle to keep customers coming back as colder days approach, Oakberry in Ireland can have a massive different outcome when it comes to profits compared to Brazil or other countries that resell Açaí, although Brazil also has cold winters, it is a tropical country,

and the weather tend to be massively warmer than Ireland even during winter, so clients will consume Oakberry's products in a less scale but they still buy it. Ireland can have colder weather compared to Spain, Australia and other countries, there are steps that Oakberry Ireland could take to keep consumers engaged even during winter, such as

1. Creating hot bowls with açai, and açai cake to go with coffee.
2. Making the shops more cozy and inviting so people see it as a comfortable place to go to during a cold day, creating winter vitamin shots with açai and offering hot drinks with an açai taste.

This way, Oakberry Ireland would be able to make a profit regardless of the time of the year.

Michael's Question: How will focusing on sustainability help Oakberry in the Irish market?

Answer: Oakberry has a strong sustainable image in comparison to its competitors, with its efforts in sourcing organic and fairtrade ingredients, their green advertising and their initiatives to use reusable packaging. This appeals to younger, more environmentally conscious consumers and allows the brand to position itself within the market as a more moral and trustworthy business. Irish consumers are fond of sustainability in their businesses, shown by the positive consumer response to OakBerry's pre-existing environmental practices.

In addition to this, by turning towards sustainable practices, Oakberry can save money in the long term. One example of this is in its packaging. By reducing the usage of unrecyclable and inefficient packaging, Oakberry reduces the cost of their waste and keep reusable. This study shows that Oakberry has already found success by tying their brand to ideals of sustainability, so it stands to reason that further aligning them with a sustainable image will only help them succeed in comparison to other competitors in the market.

Egor's Question: What key challenges did Oakberry face on its entry into the Irish market, and how did they overcome them?

Answer: Oakberry faced multiple challenges upon entering the Irish market. One of the biggest issues was the fact that acai as a health superfood was not well known to Irish consumers. This meant that customer interest was low for the business. Oakberry made efforts to educate their potential customers on acai, as well as modifying their product to include local fruits. They also partnered with local businesses, in addition to running a social media campaign to further cement themselves. This helped consumers to become more familiar with the product and increase sales.

Another key issue with the entry, was the supply chain needed for the acai berries. As acai berries are not grown in Ireland, they needed to be imported in from countries like brazil, which required complex supply chain management and increased costs. Supply chain costs caused the business to have a more limited supply in the beginning. This was mitigated through freezing the acai paste for easier travel and establishing strong supplier relationships. This reduced the risk of transporting perishable goods and allowed them to focus on establishing their business.

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